

How big a target to ask for

A plain-English guide to picking your take-profit from the size of your stop. Written 4 October 2026.

The one thing to understand

You already spotted it. Here it is measured.

When this setup works, price runs **about 50 to 60 points** in your favour. That is true whether your stop was 20 points or 130 points. The market does not know how wide your stop is and does not travel further because of it.

So R is not a measure of distance. R is a measure of *your risk*. The same 55-point move is 2.8R if your stop is 20 points and 0.4R if your stop is 130 points. Nothing about the trade changed except your stop.

The rule of thumb

Target in R = 55 divided by your stop in points

30-point stop, ask for about 1.8R. 55-point stop, ask for about 1R. 90-point stop, ask for about 0.6R.

Your guesses were close. You said 1R on a 30-point stop and half an R on a 70-point stop. The data says a shade more generous than that on both.

The lookup table

Find your stop size on the left. The percentages are how often price actually got to that target before your stop was hit.

Your stop	0.5R	0.75R	1R	1.5R	2R	3R	Trades
25pts or less	85%	79%	72%	66%	56%	49%	87
26 to 40	76%	69%	59%	50%	45%	33%	201
41 to 55	75%	61%	56%	45%	39%	25%	126
56 to 75	69%	59%	52%	41%	32%	14%	124
76 to 100	67%	57%	44%	21%	15%	4%	117
Over 100	56%	37%	25%	9%	6%	1%	167

Read the 1R column down the page: 72%, 59%, 56%, 52%, 44%, 25%. Same setup, same entry trigger, same market. The only thing that changed is how wide the stop was.

What this means in practice

A fixed 'I always take 1R' rule is not one rule. It is six different bets. On a tight stop you are leaving most of the move on the table. On a wide stop you are asking for something that happens a quarter of the time.

What to do at the desk

Measure entry to stop in points. Find your band. Do the thing in the last column and nothing else.

Your stop	What to do	What it pays
25pts or less	Set a hard 3R target and leave it alone. This is the one case where you should be greedy.	+1.41R per trade
26 to 40	Trail your stop 1R behind the best price once you are 1R up. Better than any fixed target here.	+0.59R per trade
41 to 55	Hard target at 2R or 3R. Trailing does not help in this band.	+0.39R per trade
56 to 75	Trail 0.5R behind the best price once you are 1R up. Tighter trail than the 26 to 40 band.	+0.41R per trade
76 to 100	Cap it at 1R. Move the stop to breakeven at 0.5R. Do not reach past 1R here.	+0.21R per trade
Over 100	Do not take the trade. Or take it at a fraction of your normal size.	Nothing works

'Pays' is the average result per trade in R, including the losers. Spread and commission are not in these numbers.

Three worked examples

You short at 30,800. Your stop is at 30,830.

That is a 30-point stop, so you are in the 26 to 40 band. Ask for roughly 1.8R, which is about 55 points, so a target around 30,745. But the better play in this band is to trail: once price reaches 30,770 (that is 1R), start dragging your stop to sit 30 points above the lowest price seen. You reach 1R about 59% of the time and 2R about 45% of the time.

You short at 30,800. Your stop is at 30,870.

A 70-point stop, so the 56 to 75 band. Your instinct said half an R. The data says ask for a bit more than that but manage it tighter: trail 0.5R, which is 35 points, behind the best price once you are 70 points up. You reach 1R about 52% of the time. Reaching 3R happens 14% of the time, so do not sit there waiting for it.

You short at 30,800. Your stop is at 30,920.

A 120-point stop. Walk away. Every exit rule tested on a stop this wide produces between minus 0.15R and plus 0.14R. You are risking 120 points to make nothing on average. If the stop has to be that wide, the sweep was too big and the setup is not the one you want.

About moving your stop to breakeven

Moving the stop to entry once you are 1R up is a trade, not a free lunch. You buy fewer full losses and you pay for them with fewer winners. Whether it is worth it depends entirely on your stop size.

Your stop	Reach 2R, stop left alone	Reach 2R, stop moved	Full losses, left alone	Full losses, stop moved
25pts or less	62%	60%	32%	20%
26 to 40	48%	39%	46%	25%
41 to 55	42%	30%	51%	35%
56 to 75	36%	31%	46%	34%
76 to 100	17%	16%	58%	38%
Over 100	6%	6%	33%	29%

Good trade on wide stops: at 76 to 100 points it costs you one 2R winner in seventeen and removes a fifth of your full losses. Expensive in the middle: at 26 to 40 points it costs nine winners per hundred.

The four things that would make these numbers wrong

1. Spread and commission are not included.

The cost in R is the spread divided by your stop. A 2-point spread is 0.11R on a 20-point stop but only 0.015R on a 130-point stop. So it bites the tight-stop numbers about seven times harder. The order of the table survives, but the +1.41R on tight stops is really more like +1.30R.

2. The tight-stop row has the best numbers and the weakest evidence.

A 20-point stop only happens when the sweep was small, which means that row is quietly selecting for calm market conditions. 87 trades across 51 separate level-and-day combinations.

3. The 'over 100 points' row mostly never finished.

Between a third and two thirds of those trades neither hit the target nor the stop before the day ended, against 1 to 8 per cent in the tight bands. Their numbers are based on where price happened to be at the close, not on a trade that resolved.

4. One month of a market that was going up.

19 trading days. 822 trades but only 139 separate level-and-day combinations, because one level swept six times in a day counts six times here and really only tells you one thing. Anything that favours buying is flattered by this window.

If you only remember one line

The move is about 55 points. Divide that by your stop to get your target in R. If your stop is over 100 points, there is no target that makes the trade worth taking.

Source: H25 in HYPOTHESES.md. Numbers from research/wall-studies/09_target_by_stop_size.py and 10_exit_rules.py in the CTrader-Bots repo. Not a backtest: no spread, no slippage, no commission, no partial fills, one position at a time. This tells you how big a target to ask for once you are in a trade. It does not tell you whether to be in one. Re-run both scripts after another 10 to 15 trading days before leaning on any single row.